

this PC was able to finish the test in an excellent timing of 177 seconds. But with Intel 810 chipset, any user interested in graphics should opt out, as this chipset board does not provide an AGP slot, which would be a problem if you want to upgrade later.

For users who need PCs for data-intensive applications such as word processing, spreadsheet or any database application, the **Vintron Elixir 1000** is one of the best machines available in the Budget category. Carrying a 7200-rpm drive, it delivered excellent scores in SiSoft's drive benchmarking with 34 MBps and 37 MBps in sequential write and read, respectively. This makes it quite suitable for users who need the PC for applications that frequently use the hard disk subsystem. The next best machine for these users is undoubtedly the Wipro Voyager 1100, which gave decent scores of 30 MBps and 32 MBps in sequential read and write, respectively.

There were other PCs also that boasted of good configurations, but due to a mismatch or inherent limitations in some of the components, they lost out in the overall performance. To begin with, the Amdell Value 600 PC was the only one in this category with an AMD Duron processor, which is almost as good as a P-III processor of equivalent speed. Although this PC had used a Seagate Barracuda ATA/100 drive, the speed of its hard disk subsystem was bottlenecked due to the SiS 730 motherboard that is known for poor bandwidth transfer rates on an IDE controller. It gave very poor scores of 14 and 15 MBps in sequential read and write, respectively. Similarly, the graphics used were integrated onto the SiS 730 chipset and returned very low scores of 24.1 fps and 6 fps in the normal and high quality modes of *Quake III*, respectively.

Quake III scores		Normal	High
Dell Dimension 8100		193.7	189
Amdell Monster PC 1400		77.1	25.3
HCL Beanstalk		35.8	18.6
Compaq Presario 5000		28.7	17.8
Zenith Multimedia PC 3		0	0

The top five scorers in *Quake III* (Performance systems)

One pertinent observation here is that the majority of the PCs in the sub-Rs 35,000 category had just 64 MB of RAM. This is peculiar, considering that the price of RAM is hovering between Rs 800 to Rs

Tweaks for your Brand New Machine

When your brand new computer is delivered to you, it is in its most pristine condition and your applications load blazingly fast and run really smooth. However, as you use your computer, it tends to become progressively slower and applications do not run as smoothly or as responsively as they used to.

To counter this, there are a number of little tasks and housekeeping settings that you can run on your computer to ensure that it remains running as smoothly as when you first booted it. Also, there are a plethora of settings that you can run on your computer to push it a little extra and utilise all the power that is hidden inside, making it a faster machine than it ever was before.

Restrict your startup files

Go to the Startup folder in Windows and remove any applications that are unnecessary during startup. This includes download managers, the Office Start bar, Chat clients, etc. These applications take up precious resources like memory and processing power which are invoked when you start your PC. Therefore, launch them only when you need them and you'll be freeing your computer's processing power

for applications that actually need it.

Enable DMA

This is a setting that enables your IDE devices (like the hard disk and the CD/DVD drive) to operate in a special mode that does not involve your computer's main processor when reading or writing to these devices. DMA (Direct Memory Access) is a mode of data transfer where the IDE device itself coordinates the flow of data between the hard disk and the system. Therefore, your computer's main processor is left to perform more important tasks. This particular tweak results in very big speed increases.

Load the latest drivers

Your new computer will most probably come with a pre-installed operating system or at least with the setup CDs that contain the drivers for the various hardware in your system. You are likely to have outdated drivers on your system and while your system would be working correctly, it would not be operating to its fullest potential. Remember to load the latest drivers for your hardware, especially the video card, motherboard chipset and soundcard.

900 for 64 MB, and also the fact that most of the current applications available require 128 MB or more memory to perform well.

Within this price range, if you have a restricted budget, but would need room for future upgradability, then expandability should be a key in deciding which PC to buy. Once again **Nebula Qmax Triad** proved to be a very good choice. It had six PCI slots on the board and also had a very roomy cabinet. On the other hand, the Celeron-based PCS Oriion had good looks and aesthetics but with an i810-based motherboard and a very small cabinet, you could do with a little more room for expansion.

A little of both

If you need a PC for running applications that are fairly graphics and processor intensive as well as for entertainment and gaming and are ready to shell out a little extra for a combination of performance and features, you can get decent



Wipro Voyager Flex: wrong selection of motherboard for the processor

options within a price range of Rs 35,001 to Rs 50,000. This was visible in the PCs we received with combinations of better motherboards (815 chipset instead of 810) with onboard TNT2 or Savage Pro graphics card.

Interestingly, once again this segment was dominated by Intel processor-based PCs. Out of the 17 computers in this category, there were 10 P-III machines, five P4 systems and only two AMD Athlon-based computers. This indicates that a P4 based PC, which had entered the market six to eight months ago with a price tag of